

Auwa Website

Created: April 2026. The specification for the auwa.life website — the brand's home and editorial hub. Load when building the website, planning content, or working on site structure. For implementation work (component tweaks, bug fixes, deploys), also load `context/website/patterns.md` — they're a paired set.

1. Purpose & Positioning

The auwa.life website is the front door to the Auwa brand. It establishes Auwa as a Japanese lifestyle brand rooted in philosophical awareness before the app, store, or book exist as products. The website is the first thing anyone encounters — it needs to communicate the world, not just announce a product.

What it IS: A Kinfolk-inspired editorial destination. Atmospheric, contemplative, photography-led, with journal articles as the heartbeat. A place you visit to feel something, read something beautiful, and understand what Auwa is about.

What it is NOT: A product launch page. A teaser page with an email form. A feature list. A marketing funnel. It's a brand world — the kind of site you'd bookmark and return to.

Structural references:

- **Kinfolk** (kinfolk.com) — The gold standard. Serif typography, generous whitespace, atmospheric photography, editorial authority. The grid layout of articles creates a magazine-like feel that rewards browsing.
- **Cereal** (readcereal.com) — Minimal, travel-focused, serif-heavy. Beautiful article layouts with photography that breathes.
- **Monocle** (monocle.com) — Editorial worldview extended across products, retail, and media. Clean, confident, opinionated.
- **It's Nice That** (itsnicethat.com) — Design culture editorial. Clean grid, strong typography, content-led.
- **Mubi** (mubi.com) — Dark, cinematic, serif display type. Proves dark-mode editorial can feel premium and inviting.
- **Hoshinoya** (hoshinoya.com) — Japanese luxury hospitality. Atmospheric, slow, immersive. The photography integration and pacing.

- **Aesop** (aesop.com) — Restraint as luxury. Serif type, dark palette, every detail considered.

Additional references to study:

- **The Kinfolk Table** layout style — how Kinfolk handles food/culture/travel photography within article pages
- **Apartamento** (apartamentomagazine.com) — Raw, intimate editorial photography
- **Analogue Life** (analoguelife.com) — Japanese craft curation, beautiful product storytelling
- **Snow Peak** (snowpeak.com) — How a Japanese brand presents philosophy alongside products

2. Site Architecture

All sections live under **auwa.life** with subpaths. All variants (auwalife.com, www.auwalife.com, www.auwa.life) 301 redirect to auwa.life. Google Search Console verified with sitemap submitted. Vercel project name: auwa-life.

auwa.life/	→ Home (editorial hub + brand introduction)
auwa.life/journal	→ Journal index (all articles)
auwa.life/journal/[slug]	→ Individual article (static-only: dynamicParams = false)
auwa.life/app	→ Kokoro Mirror introduction (pre-launch: coming soon with email capture)
auwa.life/store	→ Store introduction (pre-launch: coming soon with craftsman preview)
auwa.life/book	→ The Auwa story universe (pre-launch: introduction + email capture)
auwa.life/about	→ Tom & Rieko, the philosophy, the origin
auwa.life/brand	→ Living style guide (noindex, disallowed in robots.txt)
auwa.life/not-found	→ Branded 404 (src/app/not-found.tsx) – serves any unmatched URL

Internal-only routes (/brand , /book-signup): `notFound()` is called at the top of each page component when `process.env.NODE_ENV === "production"`, so they 404 in prod builds while still being viewable on `next dev`. Both routes are also listed in

`src/app/robots.ts` disallow as a belt-and-braces. `/app/sitemap.ts` lists only the real public routes and the article slugs.

Information Architecture

Home is the editorial hub — not a static landing page but a living, updating page anchored by journal content. Think Kinfolk's homepage: a hero article, a curated grid of recent pieces, and subtle navigation into the four pillars.

Journal is the SEO engine and the content heartbeat. Long-form articles, craftsman profiles, seasonal essays, Japan travel stories. This is where brand authority accumulates and where organic search traffic lands.

App, Store, Book pages are initially lightweight — atmospheric introductions that establish what's coming, with email capture. They become full sections as each pillar launches.

About tells the story of Tom and Rieko, the philosophy of Yaoyorozu no Kami, and the origin of Auwa. Written in the brand voice: quiet, precise, present.

3. Page Layouts

Home Page (Implemented)

The homepage leads with a full-bleed Auwa face video, then moves through editorial sections: an intro paragraph, two hero-scale pullquotes, a four-pillar tab module (desktop) / swipeable carousel (mobile), a Journal strip, the current micro-season, three pillar cards, a two-up article module, and the "Meet Auwa" video moment (the Auwa-kokoro footage). All images use `rounded-md`. Scroll is native across every browser. Page transitions: leaving content opacity-fades $1 \rightarrow 0$ alongside a 20vh upward drift, a Sumi (ink) wash fades in over the leaving page, then a solid panel matching the **destination page's bg** (Yoru for `/book`, Surface for everywhere else) rises from below to cover. Reveals on the new page fire AFTER the wipe via `PageReadyContext`.

Structure (top to bottom):

1. **Header** — Edge-pinned floating elements (no bar). Auwa wordmark `fixed top-6 left-6` (md/lg/xl scaled to match page gutter). Hamburger menu trigger `fixed top-6 right-6` mirrored. Sound-toggle bars sit between the two on the right cluster. Always

visible (no hide-on-scroll). Header colour is driven by a **sentinel-based tone system** (`HeaderTone / HeaderToneProvider` in `src/components/header-tone.tsx`): pages drop `<HeaderTone tone="surface|sumi|washi" />` markers inside any positioned section, a document-level `IntersectionObserver` watches them within the top 80px header band, and the most recently entered sentinel sets the active tone — separately for the LEFT half of the viewport (logo) and the RIGHT half (menu icon + sound toggle). A 5% viewport-width tolerance prevents sub-pixel rect overlap from breaking split layouts. When no sentinel is in band, per-route fallbacks apply: Surface over photographic hero, Sumi after past-hero on light pages, Washi on dark pages (`/book`). Article hero on md+ runs split (image-left sentinel `tone="surface"` , text-right sentinel `tone="sumi"`); teaser pages on lg+ run split the opposite way (text-left `tone="sumi"` , image-right `tone="surface"`). During a page-transition wipe, both elements flip against the panel theme via `useTransitionPanelTheme()` . Menu open uses a portalled full-screen overlay with centred nav items + a thin sumi/15 hairline + an Instagram link styled as a peer of the nav (sumi/45 → sumi on hover); nav items and the logo carry `data-skip-transition="true"` so clicking them inside the menu skips the page-transition wipe (the menu's own close motion serves as the visual transition). Menu close: colour flip is held for 900ms (mirror of the 200ms open delay) so the panel mostly clears the header band before the colour reverts.

2. **HeroVideo** — Full-bleed Auwa face video. `h-[100svh]` on every breakpoint so the video bottom pins to the browser bottom on desktop as well as mobile. Portrait `.mp4` on mobile, landscape on desktop. "Scroll" label + breathing vertical line replaces the bouncing chevron; the button calls native `window.scrollTo({ top, behavior: "smooth" })` with a header offset to land on the intro section.
3. **Intro block** — "Japanese Philosophy of Kokoro" `<h1>` rendered in the small-caps eyebrow style (the page's claim-layer keyword; the previous "Japanese Lifestyle Brand" was the discovery-layer phrase and was crowded by Goop/Kinfolk/Monocle territory). `ScrollFadeText` paragraph introducing Auwa and its four expressions, "Our Story" CTA linking to `/journal/the-beginning` . Desktop-only 心 (Kokoro) watermark at 3% alpha (`text-sumi/3`) behind the paragraph.
4. **Pullquote 1** — Hero-scale `ScrollFadeText` *"There is a quieter way to live, and the Japanese have been practising it for centuries. It begins with what you stop to notice."* at `clamp(2.25rem, 6vw, 4.75rem)` , leading 1.05. The closing sentence ends with concrete sensory action ("what you stop to notice"), not abstract noun phrase ("paying attention"); pullquote 1 sets up the Kokoro payoff in pullquote 2 without competing with it for sensory imagery.

5. **Four-pillar module** — Desktop (md+) renders `EditorialFrames` : a tab gallery that crossfades the active pillar's image (portrait 4:5, 480px column) with its editorial content (eyebrow, heading via `TextReveal` , body, CTA). Auto-advances every 10s (long enough for the pillar-01 video, ~9s, to play through before rotating), pauses on hover. Mobile (<md) renders `PillarParade` : horizontal overflow-x-auto row of four 3:4 cards with right-to-left reveal entrance (matches the Journal strip), dot indicators below. **The "Four ways in." <h2> is hoisted to the homepage section that wraps both variants** — only ONE canonical heading lives in the DOM regardless of which viewport-variant renders. Components return only their inner content; reintroducing an `<h2>` inside either is drift. No scroll-hijacking; no sticky transforms. Pillar CTAs are "Visit store" / "Explore World" / "Explore journal" / "Be early" (Store + App share "Be early" — both are pre-launch waitlists; "Join waitlist" is retired SaaS phrasing).
6. **Journal strip** — 11 article cards in a horizontal scrolling row. Each card: 4:5 portrait image, rounded corners, category label, title, excerpt (55 chars max). `FadeIn variant="reveal"` cascade (60ms stagger).
7. **Micro-season** — 72 micro-season kanji display (`MicroSeasonFeature`). Breathing room either side. `CtaLink` "Read the essay" to the 72 Seasons article.
8. **Three pillar cards** — "The book." / "The store." / "The app." (lowercase period-statement signature matches the four-pillar module's editorial voice; previously bare "Book / Store / App" which read transactional after the editorial buildup above). Portrait 4:5 aspect, rounded corners, gradient overlay with the lowercase pillar name + CTA underneath. CTAs: "Explore" (Book — live), "Be early" (Store and App — pre-launch). Staggered cascade `variant="reveal"` (150ms stagger). Image `alt` is a descriptive sentence with the Japanese qualifier ("Auwa Book — illustrated Japanese stories" etc.), not a one-word label.
9. **Pullquote 2** — Hero-scale `ScrollFadeText` ("In every handmade bowl..."), matching pullquote 1 size.
10. **Two-up articles** — Onsen Lesson + Nozawa Fire Festival. Two large portrait cards side by side. Staggered cascade animation. "Read the essay" label has a text-roll rollover matching the nav.
11. **Meet Auwa video moment** — `VideoMoment` component. Portrait video of the Auwa character in a rounded card (left on desktop, stacked on mobile) with descriptive text alongside. Video and heading link to `/journal/the-beginning` . "The story behind Auwa" link goes to `/about` .

12. **Footer** — Dark (`bg-void`), sticky at bottom with parallax reveal effect (content slides over it as you scroll). "Quiet letters." newsletter signup, pillar links, copyright + social icons.

Journal Index

Structure:

- Page title: "Journal" — rendered via `TextReveal` (same word-cascade entrance as the teaser H1s)
- Filter/category tags: Seasons, Craft, Philosophy, Travel (Instrument Sans, subtle)
- Article grid: Kinfolk-style cards, atmospheric photography, varied sizes
- Pagination or infinite scroll (start with pagination — cleaner, more intentional)

Journal Article Page (Implemented)

The most important page. Built with a content block system designed to map cleanly to Sanity CMS portable text.

Layout structure (top to bottom):

- **Hero** — Split layout: image left (4:5 portrait on mobile, fills viewport height on desktop), title + subtitle right-aligned
- **Meta row** — Category link, author/photographer credit (12px uppercase), social share icons (Facebook, Pinterest, X). Full-width border below.
- **Article body** — Content blocks grouped into layout sections by a `groupIntoSections()` algorithm:
 - **Text-only sections** — Text and pullquotes, always positioned on the right half (`md:ml-[50%]`). This alignment is consistent throughout the article.
 - **Image-beside sections** — Image on the left (4:5 portrait, with extra right padding to make it visually smaller), text on the right in a 50/50 grid. Text blocks that follow an image are automatically grouped beside it.
 - **Image-pair sections** — Two side-by-side images, full width, each with its own caption. Used for detail/close-up photography.
 - **Pullquotes** — EB Garamond (upright, never italic) at clamp(1.75rem, 3.5vw, 2.75rem), full opacity. Matches the homepage pullquote treatment; italic would break that consistency.
- **Full-width divider** — `border-void/8`
- **Continue reading** — 3 related article cards in a grid

- **Footer** — The shared footer component handles the newsletter signup ("Stay close.") and pillar links. No per-page newsletter section needed.

Content block types (maps to Sanity CMS):

```
type ContentBlock =
  | { type: "text"; text: string }
  | { type: "image"; src: string; alt: string; caption?: string }
  | { type: "image-pair"; images: [{ src, alt, caption? }, { src, alt,
caption? }] }
  | { type: "pullquote"; text: string }
```

The order of content blocks in the CMS determines the article layout. No manual layout selection needed — the grouping algorithm handles it automatically.

Slide-up reveals — built into the renderer. Every `FadeIn` on the article page (text blocks, pullquotes, CTAs, image-pair sections, image-beside images, hero subtitle, byline) uses `translateY={32}` instead of the default 12. This gives article body content a deliberate slide-up as sections enter the viewport, rather than the subtler rise used elsewhere. Because the 32px `translateY` lives in `renderTextBlock` and the section wrappers (not individual article data), **every future article gets this automatically** — no per-article wiring needed. The article hero image uses `ImageFade` to fade in once the image actually loads, rather than sliding.

Teaser Pages (App, Store, Book — Pre-Launch)

All three teaser pages use the **same hero layout as the article page** — this was a deliberate choice after an earlier bespoke viewport-locked flex layout on teasers caused a visible content drop on desktop Safari (font-swap recalculation resized a flex-1 image column as custom fonts loaded). Using the article-page pattern eliminates the shift.

Structure (identical across app, store, book):

```
<main>
  <div className="grid grid-cols-1 md:grid-cols-2 md:h-[calc(100dvh-
5rem)]">
    <div className="flex flex-col justify-center px-6 md:px-12 lg:px-20
xl:px-28 py-16 md:py-0">
      <TextReveal as="h1" stagger={90}>{label}</TextReveal>
      <FadeIn delay={400}><p>{body}</p></FadeIn>
      <FadeIn delay={600}><SignupForm ... /></FadeIn>
    </div>
```

```

    <div className="relative aspect-[4/5] md:aspect-auto overflow-hidden
order-first md:order-last">
      <ImageFade ... />
    </div>
  </div>
</main>

```

- Mobile: image with fixed aspect ratio on top, text block below (natural flow). No viewport-height constraint.
- md+: grid with viewport-minus-header height. Image and text side by side.
- `ImageFade` fades the image in once it actually loads.
- No Footer on teaser pages (single-viewport moments; footer would push content below the fold).

Content:

- **App:** "Awareness, daily." / body about daily practice / app-waitlist signup form / `/pillars/app.jpg`
- **Store:** "Lifetime objects." / body about craftsman objects / store-waitlist signup / `/pillars/store.jpg`
- **Book:** "Open the eyes." / body about illustrated stories / book-waitlist signup / `/pillars/book.jpg`

About Page

- Tom & Rieko's story (short, in brand voice, with photography)
- The philosophy of Yaoyorozu no Kami (accessible, not academic)
- The origin of Auwa (the name, the decade of development)
- The Eshi + Hanmoto model (brief, charming)
- Photography of Tom and Rieko (atmospheric, not corporate headshots)
- Title "The architecture / of Kokoro" uses two stacked `TextReveal` spans (second delayed 180ms) to preserve the explicit line break while keeping the word-cascade entrance

4. Design System (Implemented)

The living reference for the built website. See also the brand page at auwa.life/brand for a visual style guide.

Typography (Locked)

- **Display + Editorial:** EB Garamond (400, 500, 600, 700; normal + italic) — `font-display` in Tailwind
- **Functional / UI:** Instrument Sans (400, 500, 600) — `font-sans` in Tailwind
- **Japanese:** Noto Sans JP (300, 400) — `font-jp`; Noto Serif JP (400, 600) — `font-jp-serif`
- All loaded via `next/font/google` with `display: swap`

Type sizing rules:

- 18-19px — article body text (EB Garamond). Line-height: 1.85
- 18-20px — about page prose (EB Garamond). Line-height: 1.7
- 20-22px — card titles, pillar headings (EB Garamond). Tracking: 0.01em
- 28-32px — section headings ("Continue reading", "Stay close", "The name"). Tracking: 0.01em
- `clamp(2.25rem, 5vw, 3.75rem)` — page titles (h1) on Journal, About, and the three teaser pages. Tracking: 0.01em
- `clamp(2.5rem, 5.5vw, 4.5rem)` — article hero titles only (journal/[slug]). Tracking: 0.01em. Kept at the larger scale because the hero pairs with a full-height photograph and needs the extra weight.
- `clamp(1.75rem, 3.5vw, 2.75rem)` — pullquotes (EB Garamond, upright). Tracking: 0.005em. Pullquotes are never italic — in-article and homepage treatments match.
- `clamp(3rem, 8vw, 6.5rem)` — micro-season kanji (Noto Serif JP). Tracking: 0.06em

Uppercase tracking scale (locked). All Instrument Sans uppercase elements follow a size-based tracking scale — smaller text gets MORE letter-spacing, larger text gets LESS:

Text size	Tracking	Examples
11px	0.18em	mobile FigureHook strip
12px	0.16em	eyebrows, card categories, metadata labels, filter buttons, hero "Scroll" / "Explore" cues, breadcrumbs, share-row, footer copyright, image-overlay CTAs, bordered CtaLink buttons
14px	0.12em	navigation, form CTAs, INSTAGRAM handle

16-19px	0.10em	(rare) larger interactive caps
24px+	0.04em	display caps

This scale supersedes an earlier "single 0.14em across all uppercase" attempt that made small caps feel pinched and large caps feel airy. Mixed-case display headings (h1/h2/h3 in EB Garamond) keep their own `tracking-[0.005em] / 0.01em` values and don't follow the uppercase scale. Full reference and rationale in `context/brand/brand.md §3`.

Form CTA buttons use `font-medium` (500 weight) across all pages. All other UI text is weight 400.

Colour (Light Theme)

The website uses a warm off-white background (Surface, $\approx$ `#f8f7f4`) with the Sumi/Yoru/Washi family for text and surfaces. This is the Kinfolk-inspired editorial expression of the brand — the cosmic palette lives in the app, social, and emotional-state modules.

- **Page background:** Surface — `oklch(0.97 0.004 95) / --color-surface` ($\approx$ `#f8f7f4`). Same warm-paper family as Washi, at higher altitude. Consumed by `<main>`, the entrance loader, the hero pre-paint flash, the email body bg, and the PWA `theme_color`. Pure `#ffffff` is no longer used anywhere on the site.
- **Raised surfaces:** `oklch(0.95 0.005 250) / --color-surface-raised`
- **Text colour:** `--color-sumi (oklch(0.10 0.022 235))` at the locked opacity tiers below.

Tier	Use
100%	Headings, titles, active nav, wordmark, menu icon
80%	About page prose, footer category links
70%	Nav links, hover states, founder bios
60%	Subtitles, article subtitle
55%	Form button hover states
50%	Excerpts, captions
45%	Eyebrow labels, metadata labels (uppercase 12px), filter buttons (inactive), social share icons, "Read the latest" arrow link. Bumped from

	40% when Surface moved off pure white — 40% read softer against the warm field.
40%	Input placeholder text. Bumped from 35% for the same reason.
20%	Form underlines
10%	Default divider line. Bumped from 8% — 8% reads invisible on Surface; 10% is the floor.
3%	Kanji watermarks only (the 心 behind the homepage intro paragraph and the about page hero). The single permitted use below the 10% floor — at this level the glyph is felt rather than read, which is exactly the point. Don't promote 3% to other roles; if a new element needs to sit below 10%, it probably belongs at 10% with a different size or placement instead.

- **Borders:** Sumi at 10% (default divider), 20% (form underlines), 50% (form focus).
- **Light text on Yoru / on uniform dark surfaces:** Washi (`oklch(0.928 0.020 80)`) at the same tiers (100/80/70/60/45/40/10). Footer, FigureHook strip, SoundToggle button, dark book page, signup-form dark, cursor disc.
- **Light text over imagery / photography: Surface** (`oklch(0.97 0.004 95)`), not Washi. Used for the header logo + menu icon over the transparent hero, the pillar card text overlays, two-up CTA labels, the four-pillar module index counter, the hero "Scroll" label + line, and the book-hero card text. Surface has higher luminance and lower chroma than Washi so it cuts confidently against variable photographic mid-tones; Washi blends into bright spots. **Never use text-washi over a photograph.**
- **Kraft** (`--color-kraft` , `#BFAE9C`) — deep warm earth tone paired with Washi in `mix-blend-soft-light` overlays on BookHeroCard and EditorialFeature. Never used as text or surface on its own; always inside a `linear-gradient(135deg, var(--color-washi) 0%, var(--color-kraft) 100%)` wash that pulls cool cosmic bokeh toward the warm-paper palette of the rest of the page. If a future surface needs a "warm earth" accent, this is the token to consume; don't hardcode `#BFAE9C` anywhere.

Spacing & Layout (Implemented)

Responsive horizontal padding (page-level gutter):

- Mobile: 24px (px-6)
- Tablet: 48px (md:px-12)
- Desktop: 80px (lg:px-20)
- XL: 112px (xl:px-28)

Vertical section spacing — five tokens, locked.

Every section on the site uses one of five utility classes defined as `@utility` in `globals.css`. No bespoke `py-xx` or `pt-xx` or `pb-xx` values anywhere. Changing a token in one place propagates across every page.

Three core tokens handle the body of the page; two hero tokens handle the top airlocks. Each token solves a distinct rhythm problem — adjacent modules need a breathing gap, narrative paragraphs need tight flow, hero moments need generous airlocks, viewport-locked teaser pages need their own asymmetric padding, editorial heros need a top-only push below the header.

Token	Value	Use
<code>space-section</code>	<code>py-16 md:py-24</code> (64/96px, both sides)	Discrete modules — home page sections, journal grid, video moment. Two adjacent <code>space-section</code> sections produce a 192px gap between content, which reads as "distinct module to distinct module."
<code>space-flow</code>	<code>pb-16 md:pb-24</code> (64/96px, bottom only)	Continuous narrative — About page paragraphs, article byline, any columnar content that feels like parts of one essay. Sections flow with a single 96px gap, not doubled.
<code>space-breathing</code>	<code>py-28 md:py-44</code> (112/176px, both sides)	Hero moments — pullquotes and the 72 micro-seasons kanji module. Content that needs to stand alone and inhale.
<code>space-teaser-hero</code>	<code>pt-32 pb-16 md:pb-24 lg:pt-24</code> (top 8rem mobile/md, 6rem lg+; bottom 4rem mobile, 6rem md+)	Viewport-locked half-grid pages — <code>/app</code> , <code>/store</code> , <code>/404</code> . Top padding pulls the centred text column clear of the

		header; bottom holds it off the lower image. Tighter at lg+ where the layout flips to a 50/50 grid and the text column no longer needs as much breathing above.
space-page-hero	pt-32 md:pt-44 (top 8rem mobile, 11rem md+)	Editorial page top padding — journal index, about. Pairs with space-flow or space-section to provide the bottom rhythm. Larger md value than space-teaser-hero because these heroes scroll into the page rather than fit in one viewport, so the top airlock can breathe more.

How to pick. Ask: is this section a hero or a body section? If hero — single-viewport (teaser) → space-teaser-hero ; editorial (about, journal index) → space-page-hero . If body — independent module → space-section ; continuous narrative paragraph → space-flow ; pullquote / standalone moment → space-breathing .

Exceptions — the complete list. Outside of these, no bespoke pt-*, pb-*, or py-* belongs in page or section code.

- Header height: h-16 md:h-20 (64/80px)
- Newsletter (footer): lives inside footer.tsx — the footer has its own internal rhythm and doesn't use any section token.

Any page-section <section> in src/app/**/page.tsx or src/components/*.tsx MUST use one of the five tokens above. Hardcoded py-20 , pb-32 , pt-32 md:pt-44 , etc. are drift — treat as bugs.

Separator placement — always between sections, never inline.

The <Separator /> component is a zero-padding, full-width divider line. It sits at the exact boundary between two sections, taking no vertical space of its own. The symmetry rule: each adjacent section's padding token provides the breathing room on its own side, so a space-section → Separator → space-section boundary reads as 96px above the line and 96px below on desktop.

NEVER place a divider line inline at the top of a section (inside its top padding) — that pushes the line *into* the section's padding, making the space above the line smaller than the space below and breaking symmetry with other separators on the page. If you need a divider between sections, render `<Separator />` between them in the page tree. If the previous section flows straight into the next without a line, skip the separator entirely.

Trailing spacer before the footer. The last module on any page needs a `<div className="h-16 md:h-24" aria-hidden="true" />` before `</main>`. Between adjacent sections mid-page the total gap is $96+96 = 192\text{px}$ (two space-section padding blocks meeting); the trailing spacer recreates that gap against the footer, so the last module doesn't sit tighter to the footer than it does to the module above it.

Grid gaps:

- Article grid (journal index): `gap-x-6 md:gap-x-8 gap-y-12 md:gap-y-16`
- Pillar cards (home): `gap-5 md:gap-6 lg:gap-8`
- Horizontal scroll (home): `gap-5 md:gap-6 lg:gap-8`
- Image pairs (article): `gap-4 md:gap-6`
- Founder bios (about): `gap-8 md:gap-16`

Content widths:

- Article body text: right half of viewport (`md:ml-[50%]`)
- About page prose: `max-w-[680px]` centred
- Newsletter form: `max-w-[400px]` centred within `max-w-[480px]` container
- Waitlist forms: `max-w-[440px]`
- Horizontal scroll cards: `w-[260px] md:w-[280px] lg:w-[300px]`

Image aspect ratios:

- Primary (cards, articles, editorial): 4:5 portrait — the standard ratio everywhere
- Book cover: 3:4 portrait
- Image break (about page): 2.5:1 landscape
- Article hero (mobile): 4:5 portrait; (desktop): fills viewport height

Motion (Locked tokens)

Every animation on the site consumes the same tokens. CSS durations live in `globals.css` (`-duration-*`); JS durations, staggers, and easing live in `src/lib/motion.ts` (`DURATION`, `STAGGER`, `EASING`). Components import from `motion.ts` instead of

hardcoding ms values. Changing a token in one place propagates everywhere — FadeIn, TextReveal, hover states, page transitions, the lot.

Durations (single source of truth — `motion.ts` + `globals.css`):

Token	Value	Use
<code>DURATION.enter</code> / <code>--duration-enter</code>	800ms	FadeIn default, TextReveal — text and general reveals
<code>DURATION.reveal</code> / <code>--duration-reveal</code>	1200ms	FadeIn reveal variant — image cards, visual moments
<code>DURATION.hover</code> / <code>--duration-hover</code>	300ms	Hover and state transitions
<code>DURATION.page</code> / <code>--duration-page</code>	500ms	PageTransition crossfade

Stagger ladder — three values, no ad-hoc numbers:

Token	Value	Use
<code>STAGGER.strip</code>	60ms	Horizontal scrollers (Journal strip, PillarParade)
<code>STAGGER.grid</code>	120ms	Grid cascades (pillar cards, continue reading, two-up articles)
<code>STAGGER.hero</code>	180ms	Display-type cascades (multi-line TextReveal, stacked hero headings)

Easing — three curves only:

Token	Value	Use
<code>EASING.outExpo</code> / <code>--ease-out-expo</code> / Tailwind <code>ease-out-expo</code>	<code>cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)</code>	Brand default — fast departure, gentle arrival. "Like a breath out."
<code>EASING.inOut</code> / <code>--ease-in-out</code> / Tailwind	<code>cubic-bezier(0.65, 0, 0.35, 1)</code>	Symmetric — image crossfades, slow ambient transitions

<code>ease-in-out</code>		
<code>EASING.textRoll / --</code> <code>ease-text-roll /</code> Tailwind <code>ease-text-roll</code>	<code>cubic-bezier(0.7, 0,</code> <code>0.3, 1)</code>	Text-roll hover rollovers (CTAs, nav items, scroll label) — punchier "snap into place" feel, sharper than outExpo

FadeIn mechanics (fixed):

- `variant="fade"` (default): 12px rise, `DURATION.enter`
- `variant="reveal"`: 24px rise, `DURATION.reveal`
- Root margin: `"0px 0px -40px 0px"` (fires 40px before viewport edge); extended to `"0px 200% 0px 0px"` for horizontal scrollers so off-viewport-right cards fire when the section scrolls in
- No `will-change` toggling (Safari layer-teardown jitter — see `website-patterns.md`)

Hardcoded ms values are drift. If you see `duration-500`, `800ms`, or `delay={150}` in a component, it should come from `motion.ts` instead. Treat as a bug.

Photography Treatment

All photography follows brand.md Section 6. Portrait-first (4:5) for all editorial and card imagery — no landscape images in article layouts or grids.

5. Technical Architecture

Stack

- **Framework:** Next.js 15 (App Router, React Server Components, webpack)
- **Styling:** Tailwind CSS 4 (PostCSS plugin, OKLCH colour system via `@theme inline` in `globals.css`)
- **CMS:** Sanity (headless — not yet integrated; content currently hardcoded as placeholder data)
- **Hosting:** Vercel (automatic deployments, edge functions, image optimisation)
- **Email:** Resend (fully integrated — welcome emails auto-send on signup, newsletter sends via API). Templates in `src/emails/` using React Email (`@react-email/components`).

- **Analytics:** Vercel Analytics (`@vercel/analytics/react` , added to `layout.tsx`). Privacy-respecting, no cookie banner needed, GDPR compliant.
- **Fonts:** Google Fonts via `next/font` (EB Garamond, Instrument Sans, Noto Sans JP, Noto Serif JP)

Sanity Content Model

```
// Journal Article
{
  title: string
  slug: slug
  publishedAt: datetime
  category: reference → Category
  heroImage: image (with hotspot)
  excerpt: text
  body: portable text (rich text with images, pull quotes, embeds)
  author: reference → Author
  seoTitle: string
  seoDescription: text
  relatedArticles: array of references → Article
}

// Category
{
  title: string // Seasons, Craft, Travel, Philosophy
  slug: slug
  description: text
}

// Author
{
  name: string
  role: string
  image: image
  bio: text
}

// Page (for App, Store, Book, About – editable)
```

```

{
  title: string
  slug: slug
  heroImage: image
  body: portable text
  seoTitle: string
  seoDescription: text
}

```

```

// Newsletter subscribers are handled directly via Resend Contacts API.
// No Sanity schema needed. See context/marketing/newsletter.md for details.

```

Image Pipeline

- Sanity's image CDN handles responsive sizing, format conversion (WebP/AVIF), and cropping
- All images uploaded at 2x resolution minimum (2400px wide for full-width heroes)
- Hotspot cropping set in Sanity Studio for each image (ensures correct focal point across aspect ratios)
- Lazy loading for below-fold images (Next.js Image component handles this)
- Target: 95+ Lighthouse performance score

Component Library

Reusable components live in `src/components/`. All are server components unless noted.

Component	File	Client?	Purpose
Header	<code>header.tsx</code>	Yes	Rendered once in <code>layout.tsx</code> inside <code><HeaderToneProvider></code> so it can read sentinel tones. Sits OUTSIDE <code>PageTransition</code> so the logo + menu button stay above page-leave animations. Mobile menu is portalled to

			body. Morphing hamburger ↔ X via inline-style transitions; all three lines share matched compositor-layer hints (willChange: "top, transform", transformOrigin: 50% 50%, both backfaceVisibility properties, transform always set) so mobile Chromium / iOS Safari rasterise them at the same stroke width.
HeaderTone / HeaderToneProvider / useHeaderTone	header-tone.tsx	Yes	Sentinel-based dynamic tone system. HeaderToneProvider mounts in layout.tsx ; runs a single document-level IntersectionObserver against every [data-header-tone] sentinel within the top-80px header band, with a 5% viewport-width tolerance on the left/right split. <HeaderTone tone="..." side="left
Footer	footer.tsx	No	"Stay close" newsletter signup (dark), pillar

			links, copyright + social icons. Sticky at bottom with parallax reveal.
SignUpForm	signup-form.tsx	Yes	Email signup form. Props: <code>source</code> (app-waitlist / store-waitlist / book-waitlist / newsletter), <code>buttonText</code>, <code>successMessage</code>, <code>theme</code> (light/dark), <code>className</code>. Posts to <code>/api/signup</code>. Input, button, and success message all use <code>text-[16px]</code> (not 14px) to prevent iOS Safari's focus auto-zoom — anything under 16px fires the zoom, which pushed the submit button off-screen on smaller iPhones.
FadeIn	fade-in.tsx	Yes	IntersectionObserver-based animation. Two variants: <code>"fade"</code> (default, 12px rise) and <code>"reveal"</code> (slides in from the right, for image cards). Accepts <code>className</code>, <code>delay</code>, <code>duration</code>, <code>translateY</code>, <code>variant</code>. Article pages pass

			<code>translateY={32}</code> for a more pronounced slide-up on body content.
StripReveal	<code>strip-reveal.tsx</code>	Yes	Module-level reveal for horizontal scrollers. One <code>IntersectionObserver</code> fires when the container enters viewport and cascades all children in with CSS transition-delay stagger. Replaces per-card <code>FadeIn</code> in horizontal scrollers — the per-card approach fails on narrow viewports (<code>rootMargin 200%</code> only catches the first ~3 cards). After first reveal, swiping right shows already-revealed cards. Props: <code>className</code>, <code>itemClassName</code>, <code>stagger</code>, <code>translateX</code>.
TextReveal	<code>text-reveal.tsx</code>	Yes	Word-by-word text animation. Splits text into words, each rises from below with stagger. For hero headlines. Props: <code>as</code> (tag), <code>delay</code>, <code>stagger</code>. Used on teaser H1s ("Open the eyes.", "Awareness, daily.", "Lifetime objects.") and on the

			Journal + About page titles. For explicit multi-line headings (e.g. About's "The architecture / of Kokoro"), stack two TextReveal spans with <code>as="span"</code> <code>className="block"</code> and <code>delay={180}</code> on the second so the cascade flows from line 1 into line 2.
PageTransition	<code>page-transition.tsx</code>	Yes	Single-pass bottom-up wipe on route change. Wraps children in <code>layout.tsx</code> (which itself sits inside <code><HeaderToneProvider></code>). Phases — LEAVE (1800ms): leaving content opacity-fades <code>1 → 0</code> alongside a <code>20vh</code> upward drift, a Sumi (ink) wash fades <code>0 → 0.8</code> over the leaving page, a solid panel rises from <code>translateY(100%)</code> to <code>0</code> covering everything; the panel's bg matches the DESTINATION page (Yoru for <code>/book</code>, Surface elsewhere), so the moment it snaps off the user sees the same plane behind it. HOLD (100ms): panel

			covers; new page mounts behind. SETTLE: panel teleports back to <code>translateY(100%)</code> with no transition, wash snaps to opacity 0. Reveals (FadeIn / TextReveal / StripReveal / ImageFade) gate on <code>usePageReady()</code> so the new page's cascades fire AFTER the wipe completes — <code>revealReady</code> flips true 200ms after settle. Easing: <code>cubic-bezier(0.87, 0, 0.13, 1)</code> (in-out-quart) on every property. <code>prefers-reduced-motion</code>: navigation is instant, no panel. Internal navigations carrying <code>data-skip-transition="true"</code> (menu items, logo when menu is open) skip the wipe entirely — <code>revealReady</code> still gates so the destination page's cascades wait for the menu's own close motion to finish.
HeroVideo	<code>hero-video.tsx</code>	Yes	Full-bleed video hero for the live homepage.

			h-[100svh] on all viewports (no desktop aspect cap), so the video bottom pins to the browser bottom whatever the monitor ratio. Portrait .mp4 on mobile, landscape on desktop. "Scroll" label + breathing vertical line is a <button> that calls native window.scrollTo({ top, behavior: "smooth" }) with a header offset to land on the intro.
EditorialFrames	editorial-frames.tsx	Yes	Desktop (≥md) four-pillar module. Tab gallery crossfading through four frames (Store / Book / Journal / App) with staggered reveal per frame (eyebrow → TextReveal heading → body → CTA). Image column pinned at 480px, text column flexible, grid template [480px_1fr] , lg:gap-28 horizontal gap, max-w-[1100px] lg:mx-auto . Auto-advance every 10s (ADVANCE_MS =

			10000) so the pillar-01 video plays fully through; pauses on hover; rotation gated on a one-shot IntersectionObserver so the module always opens at pillar 01 / Store regardless of how long the user lingered on the hero. Image crossfade: 1500ms cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1) (symmetric ease-in-out, gentle).
PillarParade	pillar-parade.tsx	Yes	Mobile (<md) four-pillar module. Horizontal overflow-x-auto row of four 3:4 cards mirroring the Journal strip (native scroll, no snap, no touch-action override). Cards at w-[72vw] max-w-[360px] so card 2 peeks clearly. FadeIn variant="reveal" with revealDistance={40} so the right-to-left cascade matches the Journal strip without pushing card 2 below the IntersectionObserver's 10% threshold. Dot

			indicators update via scroll listener on the scroller element.
VideoMoment	<code>video-moment.tsx</code>	Yes	"Meet Auwa" section: portrait video card + text. Desktop: side-by-side. Mobile: stacked.
AuwaVideoBlock	<code>auwa-video-block.tsx</code>	Yes	Full-width Auwa face video. Landscape desktop, square mobile. Auto-plays on visibility.
MicroSeason	<code>micro-season.tsx</code>	Yes	Displays current 72 micro-season with kanji.
ObfuscatedEmail	<code>obfuscated-email.tsx</code>	Yes	Bot-proof email display. Shows <code>user[at]domain</code> initially, reveals real <code>mailto:</code> link on click. Props: <code>user</code> , <code>domain</code> .
ImageFade	<code>image-fade.tsx</code>	Yes	Next.js <code><Image></code> wrapper that fades from opacity 0 → 1 over <code>DURATION</code> . reveals once pixels are painted. Used on the article hero AND all editorial card images (journal index, in-article image-pair / image-beside, continue-reading). Cache-guard on mount: <code>img.complete</code>

			<code>&& naturalWidth > 0</code> flips <code>loaded</code> directly so cached images on revisits don't stay at opacity 0 (onLoad never fires for them). Inline <code>transition</code> re-specifies <code>transform</code> + <code>filter</code> alongside opacity so the global <pre>a img { transition: transform 0.8s ... } </pre> hover-zoom rule isn't wiped by the inline opacity transition.
FigureHook	<code>figure-hook.tsx</code>	Yes	Sitewide bottom peek strip inviting visitors to the figure edition waitlist. Mounted in <code>layout.tsx</code>. Hidden on teaser pages (<code>/store</code> , <code>/app</code> , <code>/book</code>) where a local signup is already primary. Appears after 600px scroll, fades out as a zero-height sentinel at the end of <code><main></code> enters the viewport (240px pre-footer margin so the handoff to the footer's "Quiet letters" block is gentle). Sentinel watches main-content-

			end, not the sticky footer directly — the footer is <code>sticky bottom-0</code> from page load and would register as intersecting at every scroll position. Snap discipline: the strip uses a <code>snap</code> flag (true on mount + path change, cleared via two <code>requestAnimationFrame</code> hops) to disable the <code>opacity+transform</code> transition for the first committed render after navigation — without that, navigating to a new article from a page where the strip was visible animated the strip's <code>translate</code> from 0% to 100%, producing a brief 10px dark lip flash at the bottom on article load.
SoundToggle	<code>sound-toggle.tsx</code>	Yes	Sound bars rendered inside <code>header.tsx</code> as part of the right cluster (between logo and menu, sharing the header's colour stream so the three read as one row). Off-state: bars hold an asymmetric equaliser pose <code>[0.55,</code>

0.85, 0.4, 0.7] (varying scaleY) so the icon reads as audio at a glance, not as four stacked dots. Playing: sound-wave keyframe animates scaleY per bar with staggered durations + delays. All bars share matched compositor-layer hints (willChange: transform, both backfaceVisibility properties, transform always set even when playing — including the scaleY(1) rest value during animation, never undefined) — same fix as the hamburger lines for mobile Chromium / iOS Safari rasterising siblings at different widths.

visibilitychange + pagehide listeners pause playback so iOS doesn't keep a ghost media badge when the tab backgrounds. A SECOND, standalone <SoundToggle /> mount in

			<code>layout.tsx</code> is currently parked (commented out) — that one was the older sitewide floating button. The header-cluster mount is the active one.
--	--	--	--

API routes:

Route	Purpose
<code>/api/signup</code>	Creates Resend contact + sends welcome email. Accepts <code>{ email, source }</code> .
<code>/api/newsletter/send</code>	Sends newsletter to full audience. Accepts content JSON + secret token.

Email templates (in `src/emails/`, React Email components, not rendered on the website):

Template	Purpose
<code>welcome.tsx</code>	Auto-sent on signup. 4 variants based on source.
<code>newsletter.tsx</code>	Manual newsletter sends. Accepts heading, intro, articles array, hero image.

SEO

Messaging strategy — three layers, applied consistently across every page. Each layer has a distinct job; they don't compete:

- **Discovery** (what a new visitor types into Google): *"Japanese lifestyle brand"*. Used in meta descriptions, About page prose, Instagram bio, press briefings, the dinner-party answer. Instantly legible, places Auwa next to Kinfolk / Monocle / Goop in a new visitor's mental shelf.
- **Claim** (the unique ground Auwa owns in search): *"Japanese Philosophy of Kokoro"*. Used in the homepage title tag and homepage H1. "Kokoro" is a low-competition word Auwa essentially claims outright; "Japanese Philosophy" is the higher-volume bucket the brand competes for. Titles and H1s enforce this claim.

- **Voice** (editorial prose tone): *"Japanese living"*. Thread through article intros, About narrative, newsletter prose, Instagram captions. Aspirational, not category-descriptive.

Title pattern — " | " (space-pipe-space) separator. Every page matches this structure:

Page	Title
/	Auwa Japanese Philosophy of Kokoro
/journal	Auwa Journal Japanese Philosophy, Craft & Seasons
/about	About Auwa A Japanese Lifestyle Brand
/store	Auwa Store Japanese Craftsman Objects & Figure Editions
/app	Auwa App Japanese Awareness Practice
/book	Auwa Book Illustrated Japanese Stories
/journal/[slug]	{article.title} Auwa Journal

Every title stays ≤60 chars (Google truncates after that). Every title contains "Japanese" somewhere — either as the category qualifier ("Japanese Awareness Practice") or in the unique-claim phrase ("Japanese Philosophy of Kokoro").

Meta description pattern — 100-155 chars, keyword-rich, distinct from on-page poetry. Articles carry TWO fields:

- **subtitle** — the on-page editorial line (poetic, short, reader-facing).
- **description** — the meta description (keyword-rich, 100-155 chars, contains "Japanese" and the primary topic word). `generateMetadata()` prefers **description**, falls back to **subtitle** if absent.

This separation is important: the reader sees quiet poetry on the page; Google sees a concrete topic statement in search results.

H1 rules — one per page, keyword-led when possible:

- Homepage: **Japanese Philosophy** (rendered as the small-caps eyebrow above the intro paragraph — visually unchanged, semantically elevated).

- `/journal`: `Journal` (short category label is fine; the title tag carries the keyword weight).
- `/about`: The architecture of Kokoro (poetic; the title tag does the SEO work).
- Teaser pages (`/app`, `/store`, `/book`): topic H1s (`Awareness`, `daily.`, `Lifetime objects.`, `Open the eyes.`).
- Articles: `article.title`. Japanese topic words (Yakushima, Shigefusa, Yaoyorozu no Kami) ARE the H1.

Structured data (JSON-LD) — one per page type, injected via `<script type="application/ld+json">`:

- `/` — `Organization` + `WebSite` (in `layout.tsx`).
- `/journal` — `Blog` with `BlogPosting` entries for every article.
- `/about` — `AboutPage` with `Organization` `mainEntity` containing `Person` entries for Rieko Maeda (Creator, Japanese) and Tom Vining (Producer, British).
- `/journal/[slug]` — `Article` with headline, description, author, `datePublished`, publisher, image, url.
- Teaser pages (`/store`, `/app`, `/book`) — no structured data yet; add `Store` / `SoftwareApplication` / `Book` schemas when they launch.

Canonical URLs — intentionally NOT emitted. The root layout used to set `alternates.canonical = "https://auwa.life"`; Next.js metadata inheritance then applied that canonical to every child page, which told Google every article was a duplicate of the homepage — and collapsed them under homepage consolidation. Fix (April 2026): remove the global canonical entirely. Each URL is now its own canonical by default. Only add `alternates: { canonical: url }` on a specific page if that page genuinely needs one (e.g. to strip query params).

Image alt text — always include the geographic, cultural, or craft qualifier where it reads natural. Prefer Japanese terms (`washi`, `onsen`, `shimenawa`, `noren`, `engawa`) over English translations — they rank on image search AND feel editorial. Prefer place names (Yakushima, Koya-san, Nagano) over `"mountain"` / `"forest"`. Hero image alt should identify Japan or the specific Japanese subject within the first ten words.

Sitemap slug hygiene. The sitemap's `articleSlugs` array MUST match the keys in the `articles` object in `src/app/journal/[slug]/page.tsx` byte-for-byte. A single-character drift (`oroko-combs` vs `oroku-gushi`) means Google crawls a 404 and never discovers the real URL. Fixed once; the article command now guards against it.

Journal articles are the primary SEO asset — target long-tail keywords around Japanese philosophy, craft, seasonal living, awareness. Each article's **description** should combine "Japanese" + the specific topic term + a brief what-it's-about sentence.

6. Build Approach

vo / Stitch Prompt Ideas

Use vo.dev or Stitch to rapidly scaffold pages, then refine in Claude Code. Prompts should be specific and reference-heavy:

Homepage prompt: "Create a dark-mode editorial homepage inspired by Kinfolk magazine. Serif display typography (Cormorant), sans-serif navigation (Inter or similar). Full-width hero with atmospheric photography and large headline overlay. Below: a brand statement line centred with generous whitespace, then a 3-column asymmetric article card grid (varied card sizes, dark backgrounds, warm photography). Minimal footer with wordmark. Overall feel: Japanese luxury hospitality meets design magazine. Colour: near-black backgrounds (#0f0f14), off-white text (#dddde2), subtle yellow-green accent (#c4cc5a). Tailwind CSS."

Article page prompt: "Create a long-form article page with dark background. Full-width hero image with parallax. Large serif headline (Cormorant) centred below hero. Article body in a narrow column (max 680px) with generous line-height. Pull quotes in larger serif, centred. Full-width photography interspersed. Author block at bottom. Related article cards (2-3) below. Newsletter signup at end. Dark, atmospheric, editorial. Think Cereal magazine online."

Journal index prompt: "Create a magazine-style article index page with dark background. Page title in large serif. Filter row with category tags. Article cards in asymmetric grid — mix of large (spanning 2 columns) and standard cards. Each card: atmospheric image, serif headline, one-line excerpt, category badge. Hover: subtle scale and brightness shift. Kinfolk/Cereal aesthetic. Dark mode."

Build Timeline (Achievable in a Few Days)

Day 1: Scaffold + Homepage

- Set up Next.js 16 + Tailwind 4 + Sanity
- Scaffold homepage layout (vo/Stitch for initial structure, Claude Code for refinement)
- Configure fonts (Cormorant, Instrument Sans, Noto Sans JP)

- Implement colour system (OKLCH custom properties in Tailwind config)
- Homepage: header, hero, brand statement, article grid (with placeholder content), newsletter signup, footer

Day 2: Article Pages + Journal Index

- Journal article page template (the most important page)
- Journal index with category filtering
- Sanity content model for articles, categories, authors
- Sanity Studio configured with preview
- Responsive testing across breakpoints

Day 3: Remaining Pages + Polish

- App, Store, Book pre-launch pages (atmospheric, simple)
- About page
- Newsletter integration (Resend)
- Motion: scroll reveals, hover states, page transitions
- SEO: meta tags, OG images, structured data
- Performance optimisation, Lighthouse audit
- Deploy to Vercel, connect domain

Day 4: Content Population

- Populate initial journal articles (see Section 7)
- Final photography treatment and upload
- Cross-browser testing
- Soft launch

7. Preparing Initial Articles (The Day-One Content Plan)

The website needs content on day one. An empty journal undermines the editorial positioning. Aim for 8-10 articles prepared and ready to publish at launch — a mix that showcases the four content territories (seasons, craft, travel, philosophy) and gives the site enough density to feel established.

Article Preparation Approach

Tom and Rieko can prepare ~10 articles in a focused day using this workflow:

1. **Select 10 topics** from the list below
2. **Gather photography** from Tom's 15+ year Japan catalogue (already shot, just needs selection and Lightroom treatment)
3. **Write first drafts** — Tom writes in brand voice, 800-1500 words per article. Some can be shorter (500-word seasonal reflections). Use Claude to help draft, then edit for voice and authenticity.
4. **Rieko reviews** for cultural accuracy and adds Japanese terms/context
5. **Apply photography treatment** (Lightroom "Auwa — Atmospheric" preset)
6. **Upload to Sanity** with metadata, hero images, categories, SEO descriptions

Suggested Initial Articles

Seasons (2-3 articles):

- "The Fifth Day" — An introduction to how Japan divides the year into 72 micro-seasons, and what it means to notice the world in five-day increments. Photography: seasonal Japan landscapes.
- "Seimei (清明): The Light Returns" — A seasonal essay tied to the current micro-season at launch. Atmospheric, personal, grounded in a specific place and moment in Japan.

Craft (2-3 articles):

- "The Knife Maker of Seki" — Profile of a craftsman Tom and Rieko met during their Monolise research. The story of a lifetime spent perfecting a single craft. Photography from the workshop visit.
- "Objects with Kokoro" — An essay on the philosophy of choosing lifetime objects over disposable ones. Why a hand-forged knife or a ceramic cup from a master artisan changes your relationship with daily life.
- "What Wabi-Sabi Actually Means" — Reclaiming the concept from Instagram aesthetics. What it means to find beauty in imperfection and impermanence, beyond the interiors trend.

Travel (2-3 articles):

- "Temple Mornings" — An atmospheric essay about the ritual of visiting Japanese temples at dawn. The silence, the light, the practice of being present. Photography: Tom's temple work.
- "The Onsen Lesson" — On the Japanese bathing culture and what it teaches about shared space, vulnerability, and attention. Not a guide — a reflection.

Philosophy (2-3 articles):

- "Everything Has Kokoro" — The foundational essay. An accessible introduction to Yaoyorozu no Kami and why it matters in modern life. The philosophical anchor for the entire journal.
- "Awareness, Not Mindfulness" — Why Auwa uses the word "awareness" instead of "mindfulness." The difference between a Western self-help concept and a Japanese philosophical worldview.
- "The Guest" — On being a respectful visitor to Japan (and to any culture). The awareness that comes from understanding you are in someone else's home. Photography: Japan travel moments.

Content Calendar (Post-Launch)

After the initial 10 articles, publish 1-2 articles per week aligned with the 72 micro-seasons content calendar. Each micro-season (5 days) is an opportunity for a seasonal essay, craftsman profile, or travel piece. This gives the journal a natural rhythm without feeling forced.

8. Newsletter & Email

Fully documented in `context/marketing/newsletter.md`. Summary:

- **Welcome emails** auto-send on signup (4 variants per source: newsletter, app-waitlist, store-waitlist, book-waitlist). Sent as transactional via `resend.emails.send()`. Unsubscribe is a plain `mailto:hello@auwa.life?subject=Unsubscribe` because the `{{RESEND_UNSUBSCRIBE_URL}}` merge var does not substitute in transactional sends.
- **Welcome email subjects:** "Welcome to Auwa" (newsletter) · "You're on the Auwa App waitlist" (app) · "A note from Auwa." (store and book — softer subject keeps them out of Gmail Promotions).
- **Newsletter sends** go through Resend's **Broadcasts API** (`resend.broadcasts.create()` + `.send()`), not the transactional Emails API. This is what enables the `{{RESEND_UNSUBSCRIBE_URL}}` merge variable and the `List-Unsubscribe` header. Triggered manually via the `/marketing/newsletter` slash command or the `/api/newsletter/send` endpoint.
- **Signup points:** shared footer on every page ("Quiet letters."), plus dedicated forms on app/store/book teaser pages
- **Templates:** React Email components in `src/emails/` (welcome.tsx, newsletter.tsx)

- **Resend segments:** App Waitlist, Store Waitlist, Book Waitlist (3 segments, free plan limit). Newsletter subscribers go to audience without a segment.
- **Subject format:** [Topic] | Auwa — poetic, not clickbait

Social share previews (journal articles)

Each article has a dedicated 1200×630 landscape OG image at `/journal/{slug}/{slug}-og.jpg`, alongside the portrait 4:5 hero. `generateMetadata()` in `src/app/journal/[slug]/page.tsx` derives the OG path from the hero filename. FB, Pinterest, and X pull this image into their link previews. Instagram is intentionally not supported — IG has no link-share flow. To regenerate after a hero change:

```
cd website/main/public/journal/{slug} && cp {slug}-hero.jpg {slug}-og.jpg
&& \
  sips --resampleWidth 1200 {slug}-og.jpg && sips -c 630 1200 {slug}-
og.jpg
```

9. Analytics & Performance

- **Vercel Analytics** — installed and live. `@vercel/analytics/react` in `layout.tsx`. Privacy-respecting, no cookie consent banner needed.
 - **Key metrics:** Page views, unique visitors, time on page (especially journal articles), newsletter signups (conversion rate by page), referral sources
 - **Lighthouse target:** 95+ across all categories
 - **Core Web Vitals:** LCP < 2.5s, FID < 100ms, CLS < 0.1
-

10. Awwwards Submission Checklist

Baked in from the April 2026 SOTD-prep pass. CLAUDE.md carries the full list of learnings; this section is the quick site-level audit before any submission.

- Branded `src/app/not-found.tsx` renders for any unmatched URL (test with `/definitely-not-a-page`).
- Every dynamic slug route (`/journal/[slug]`) calls `notFound()` for unknown slugs AND exports `generateStaticParams + dynamicParams = false`. Never fall

through to a fallback article.

- Internal-only routes (`/brand` , `/book-signup`) are guarded by `notFound()` under `process.env.NODE_ENV === "production"` so they 404 in prod builds. They're also disallowed in `src/app/robots.ts`.
- `src/app/manifest.ts` exists with `name`, `theme_color`, `icons`. Both `favicon.svg` and `apple-touch-icon.png` present.
- Every top-level route exports its own `openGraph.images` + `twitter.images` at `1200×630`. OG files under `public/og/{page}.jpg`. Article OGs live at `public/journal/{slug}/{slug}-og.jpg` — the `write-article` command now covers generation.
- All site imagery uses `next/image` (including inside horizontal scrollers with `loading="eager"` and `priority={i < 2}` on the first two cards — the default lazy-load heuristic misses off-viewport-right cards on iOS).
- `globals.css` has a `:focus-visible` ring. No component strips it with `outline-none` without an explicit replacement.
- Icon-only buttons carry `aria-label`; decorative inline SVG gets `aria-hidden="true"`.
- `SoundToggle` inverts over the dark footer via `IntersectionObserver`, and pauses on `visibilitychange` + `pagehide`.
- `EditorialFrames` auto-advance is gated on an IO one-shot so rotation only starts when the module enters the viewport — first-time visitors see pillar 01 / Store first.